

Testimony of Juan Giarizzo (Philadelphia Regional Hearing)

Good Morning, Chairman Grove and Democratic chairman Conklin and of course my State Representative Brian Simms and members of the committee.

Thank you for the opportunity to present my testimony before the committee. I am a Venezuelan American Immigrant and an active community leader for the Venezuelan and Hispanic community in the city of Philadelphia. I act as the executive director of Gente de Venezuela, a nonprofit organization focused on the support of Venezuelan immigrants in the area of Philadelphia and the United States, we provide support to immigrants in the shape of advocacy, donations and assisted releases to immigration detainees, promote vaccination campaigns, while promoting our culture.

Additionally, I am also a founding member of the Alianza Latina of PHL, a group of hispanic community leaders that decided to organize together in order to increase the political participation of the members of our communities and promote strategic alliances between our groups.

Today I am here because I am fully aware that we are approaching the moment to outline the congressional district maps that will determine the opportunity of my community to access political representation in key political spaces. Political representation is key to access resources and cracking or packing districts will negatively impact my community that is historically politically underrepresented which leads to lack of trust in the political and legislative process.

Based on census data we see a growth in the Hispanic community in Philadelphia and PA, for example North Philadelphia. The same census data shows that other areas of the commonwealth have lost population, for example the 15th district (Center West Pennsylvania); this reduction of population should be reflected in the new maps.

We are now over a million hispanic people in the commonwealth. We should have a fair map that will allow us to maintain our current representation and avoid the fracture of districts with a common interest population.

I would like to ask this committee to guarantee that the new maps follow the 2018 supreme court verdict and do not divide those districts that have experienced a population growth (for example the 3rd and 2dn district). Even if I reside in the 3rd district, the majority of the population I serve resides in the 2dn district. I have witnessed the growth of the Hispanic population in that particular area and I want to ask that this is reflected in the new maps